

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 2

♥ J 8 6

♦ A 3

♣ J 7 4 2

♠ 8 6 5 4

♥ A K 2

♦ Q 4

♣ A K 10 3



♠ A K 9

♥ Q 10 5 4

♦ J 10 9

♣ Q 8 6

♠ 7 3

♥ 9 7 3

♦ K 8 7 6 5 2

♣ 9 5

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

2♠

Pass

3♣

Pass

3♦

All Pass

3♦ by South

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = ? : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 3 + ?

Rather than trying to figure out how many losers this ♦ holding may produce, approach it from the other direction; you can only afford ONE loser, so you assume the cards lie in a way that will give you that result.

That means that the ♦s must be splitting 3-2, and it also means that you must knock out the ♦A without using either the ♦K or ♦Q. Can you do it?

Your only hope is for West to hold a doubleton ♦ A x. You ruff the third ♠, then play a small ♦ toward dummy's ♦ Q. When this wins the trick, play another ♦, and duck in your hand. If West's ♦ A falls you will be golden.

There are times when your only hope of making a contract is if the defender's cards lie in a particular way.

When this happens you should play as if they actually **DO** lie in that way, even though it may be against the percentages.

This hand is a perfect example - your only hope was for West to hold ♦ A x, so - you base your plan on West holding ♦ A x.

In the old days (before transfer bids) you could have just bid a "drop-dead" 2♦. But those days are gone so you must improvise. You bid 2♠, transferring partner to ♣s.

Partner says 3♣;

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Partner says 3♣;

You now bid 3♦ and partner knows to pass.

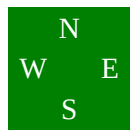
South plays 3♦. West leads the ♠Q. East overtakes and plays ♠ A K 9.

**Board 3**

South Deals  
None Vul

♠ 8 2  
♥ K 9 8 6 3  
♦ Q 7 3  
♣ Q 10 4

♠ K Q 10 9 3  
♥ Q J 4  
♦ 8 5  
♣ 6 5 2



♠ A 7 6 5  
♥ 7 5  
♦ K 10 9 4  
♣ J 9 8

♠ J 4  
♥ A 10 2  
♦ A J 6 2  
♣ A K 7 3

With 9 points and a 5-card Major suit you should definitely transfer, so you bid 2♥. Partner replies 2♠.

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Now you complete the sequence by bidding 2NT, trusting partner to put it in the right place. He has maximum points and a doubleton ♠ so he puts it in 3NT.

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          |       |      | 1NT   |
| Pass     | 2♥    | Pass | 2♠    |
| Pass     | 2NT   | Pass | 3NT   |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

3NT by South

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 5

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥6, East follows with the ♥5. What will you play from dummy? And what will you play from your hand.

It's not as bad as that Winner List looks; you can establish 4 ♠ winners very easily.

In fact, it looks so good you might wonder what could possibly go wrong. Here's something that can go wrong. The defenders take the **SECOND** ♠ trick with their ♠A. Can you get back to dummy for those other three winners?

Maybe you can and maybe you can't. It depends on what you played from your hand at the first trick. If you won that trick in your hand with the ♥A, then YES, you can get to dummy by leading twice toward the ♥Q J.

But if you won the first trick more cheaply with your ♥10, (or perhaps dummy's ♥J), and you still have that ♥A in your hand then West will prevent you from ever getting to dummy.

It is ingrained in Bridge players to win tricks with the smallest card possible. And while that is usually a good idea it can sometimes be a huge mistake.

Suppose you win the first trick with your ♥10. If you later play your ♥A then West's ♥K will stop you from getting to dummy. But if instead you play a small ♥ toward the ♥Q J West will grab his ♥K and your own ♥A will block your entry.

But if you take the first trick with a "spendthrift" ♥A then dummy's ♥Q J will become a guaranteed entry to the ♠s.

And notice - no matter which way you play it you still end up with exactly 2 ♥ tricks. So the play doesn't cost a trick, it just gains an entry.